Bharat Jodo: The Power of Love

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> *'The day the power of love overrules the love of power, the world will know peace.'*
>
> *—Mahatma Gandhi*

Our freedom struggle found its shape and character when Mahatma Gandhi travelled across India to understand the nation. Before starting his satyagraha movement, Gandhi ji sought to travel the country via the railways to understand the integral threads of the great and diverse social fabric of India. As promised to his friend Gopal Krishna Gokhale, a leader of the Indian National Congress, he put himself on a 'probation period' and flagged off his travels.

What I witnessed in September 2022 was a similar resolve, similar grit and similar desire—to know the nation. Rahul Gandhi's decision to undertake the Bharat Jodo Yatra was not just a landmark event in India's history—it redefined Indian polity too. Never in independent India has a mass-contact programme of this magnitude been undertaken by any political leader. A walk from the beaches of Kanyakumari in the south to the snowcapped peaks of Kashmir up in the north. Almost 4,000 kilometres on foot with a message of peace, harmony and partnership.

I was barely a month into my new role as chairperson of Social Media and Digital Platforms at the Indian National Congress, when Rahul Gandhi took the decision to start the iconic Yatra. While the idea of the Yatra was liberating, it was a big task in my official capacity. The challenge was to ensure our social media platforms did justice to the effort that was being put on the ground. One had no clue about the kind of content it would generate,